

WHY YOU CAN'T BEAT TRAFFIC

The morning of December 15, 1973, was not an especially eventful date. John Paul Getty III, the grandson of the oil tycoon, was released from his kidnapping. Idi Amin, the dictator of Uganda, launched a mocking "Save Britain Fund" with £600 of his own money. And in New York City, a road collapsed, proving, remarkably, that the amount of traffic congestion in a city is only tangentially linked to the amount of road space.

The road was the West Side elevated highway, one of the world's first "freeways"—that is, a road segregated from pedestrians and the street to allow vehicles to move faster, with grade separated crossings and entrance and exit ramps to connect it to other streets. It was built between 1929 and 1951, long before President Dwight Eisenhower set aside the money to build them all over America, and when it finally opened, stretching from the southern tip of Manhattan all of the way up to Seventy-Second Street on the Upper West Side, it became a symbol of New York's postwar vitality. Simeon Strunsky, a *New York Times* editorialist, described it as Robert Moses's best work. "The traveler comes and goes in a setting of beauty which [it] is not too much to call intoxicating," he wrote. It meant that tens of thousands of workers on Wall